

Digital Literature Review

ENG487 ú MW3-4:15 ú RB284

Instructor Information

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Course Description

The Apple TV series, *Severance*, is a sci-fi literalization of the idea that we exist differently in different spaces—that not just our activities but our very identities depend on the spaces we occupy. In this year's DLR, we will dig into the connection between space/spaces and our selves and societies. Course reading and viewing will allow us to consider both physical spaces (landscapes, cities, and domestic spaces) and theoretical spaces (liminal and hybrid spaces, inner space, and digital space). We will (1) explore the ways in which these spaces shape us, (2) critique social constructions of space, and (3) consider what is gained when we imagine “impossible” spaces. Students will be introduced to the “spatial turn” in literary studies and will also explore how conversations focused on space show up in other fields (such as geopolitics and ecocriticism).

Students in the course will also conduct their own research, design an issue of the *Digital Literature Review* journal, and develop a publicity campaign to both solicit journal submissions and promote the issue we create as a class. English majors will complete their capstone projects in this course (earning ENG 444 credit), and all students will gain invaluable analytical, writing, editing, publishing, marketing, and digital media skills.

Course Materials

Calvino, Italo. *Invisible Cities*: ISBN: 9780156453806

Robinson, Marilynne. *Housekeeping*. ISBN: 978-0312424091

Wilson, “Fences” (available online)

We will view selected episodes of the AppleTV series *Severance* together in class. We will also look at Chris Ware's *Building Stories* in class, but students are *not* expected to obtain this text for themselves. Other course materials (including poetry, short stories, and critical theory) will be made available on Canvas.

Course Assignments and Assessments

GRADING CONTRACT

In this course, we will employ [contract grading](#), which means that your grade for the course will be based on the *quantity* of satisfactory work that you complete. The *quality* of work will be assured by meeting assignment specifications and by engaging instructor and peer feedback. Instead of assigning letter grades to your assignments, I will share my expectations for the assignment. If you meet these expectations, you will earn a “complete.” If you do not meet these expectations, you will earn an “incomplete,” and you are encouraged to revise the assignment until it is marked “complete.” Minor assignments may be revised and resubmitted until the end of the unit. **For Major Assignments, you MUST REVISE until you achieve “complete.”**

What will be required to receive an ‘A/A-’?

A grade of “complete” on MAJOR ASSIGNMENTS

A grade of “complete” on 90% or more of PARTICIPATION assignments: A (93–100), A- (90–92)

Late policy: You may turn in up to 3 late assignments with no advance notice or penalty. (Note: I will not consider an assignment late if you email me before the deadline to request an extension and propose a new deadline).

What will be required to receive a ‘B+/B/B-’?

A grade of “complete” on MAJOR ASSIGNMENTS

A grade of “complete” on 80% or more of PARTICIPATION assignments: B+ (87–89), B (83–86), B- (80–82)

Late policy: You may turn in up to 4 late assignments with no advance notice or penalty.

What will be required to receive a ‘C+/C/C-’?

A grade of “complete” on MAJOR ASSIGNMENTS

A grade of “complete” on 70% or more of PARTICIPATION assignments: C+ (77–79), C (73–76), C- (70–72)

Late policy: You may turn in up to 5 late assignments with no advance notice or penalty.

MAJOR ASSIGNMENTS:

- 2 Blog Posts
- Research Essay

Blog Posts: One of the goals of the *DLR* is to connect academic research to a broader audience. As part of that effort toward connection, we’ll be keeping a blog reporting on the *DLR*’s development, interesting research we come across, and discussions of multispecies representations in literary and popular culture. Each member of the class will be responsible for writing, revising, and publishing at least 2 posts during the semester. The Design team will be responsible for editing these posts, and the publicity team will work to develop a schedule for these posts.

Final Essay: This capstone assignment is meant to give you an opportunity to demonstrate your mastery of a variety of academic skills—analytical reading and writing, research, revision, and preparation your manuscript for publication. How you balance those skills and the form your project takes are (mostly) up to you, within some specific assignment guidelines. Your ultimate goal will be to produce a research-driven project of some kind that engages with spatiality. This project will be eligible for publication in the DLR.

PARTICIPATION ASSIGNMENTS:

- Active engagement in class discussions and one-on-one conferences
- 1 Theory presentation (group assignment)
- Completion of essay scaffolding assignments (Abstract, Annotated Bibliography, and Draft), in-class activities, and reading responses
- Projects in your Journal Teams

Class Participation: You are expected to be a thoughtful and committed presence in our class throughout the semester. Being fully present means that you should:

- come to class having read the material and completed any assigned work
- ask and answer questions
- communicate with your team
- engage with your peers and me in accordance with our common agreement.

It also means cell phones and any material not directly related to the activity, including headphones, social media, etc. need to be put away. On *DLR* work days, I expect you to devote your attention to projects related to the *DLR*.

1 Theory Presentation: You will work in small groups to read, analyze, and teach a scholarly article to your classmates. You will sign up for one scholarly article relevant to our course themes. Your presentation should introduce the article's central claims, methodologies, and relevance and draw connections to other course materials.

Essay Scaffolding Assignments: To support the development of your final essay, you will submit (1) an Abstract, in which you state your research question, provide context, and outline your argument; (2) an Annotated Bibliography, which compiles and provides citations and summaries for sources; and (3) an Essay Draft for feedback.

Journal Teams: You will be part of a team working on some aspect of the journal—editorial, publicity, or design. Each team will research best practices in its field and communicate those ideas to the class. While many elements of the journal will be developed by the class as a whole, it will be up to individual working teams to enact those decisions. On check-in days, you and your partners will provide short reports on your progress and outline your plans for the coming weeks. Because different aspects of this journal will have different deadlines and pressures, you will be expected to liaise with and even move among teams as necessary. Your grade will reflect your active participation, self-assessment, and peer evaluations.